



The Heavenly Courtroom

Sabbath School Study Notes
Lesson 6

PHASE 4 SDA BRANCH

Revelation 14:7

THE FIRST ANGEL'S MESSAGE • LESSON 6 • REVELATION 14:7

The Heavenly Courtroom

Matthew 13:24–30, 36–39 | Daniel 7:9–14 | Leviticus 16 | 1 John 2:1

Two pictures — one truth. Above: a defendant watching his advocate plead his case before a judge. Below: the High Priest entering the Most Holy Place to make atonement before the Mercy Seat. The courtroom is the model. The sanctuary is the reality.

R Recap

In Lesson 5 we established that God's judgment is not arbitrary — it is based on a complete and exact record held in three books: the Book of Misdeeds, the Book of Remembrance, and the Book of Life. The evidence exists. The court is ready.

Today we enter the courtroom. Our goal is to understand how God's judgment works — who the key players are, why the process is fair, and what it means for us personally.

1 Setting the Scene: The Wheat and the Tares

Matthew 13:24–30 | Matthew 13:36–39

Before we enter the courtroom, Jesus gives us a picture of why it is necessary. In the parable of the wheat and the tares, two types of plants grow in the same field. To a casual observer they look identical — until the harvest.

Element	Meaning (Matthew 13:36–39)
The Field	The world

The Good Seed	The sons of the kingdom
The Tares (Weeds)	The sons of the wicked one
The Harvest	The end of the age — judgment

Jesus is not merely describing a future harvest — He is showing us that the separation of the righteous and the wicked is a *process*, not a single sudden event. That process is the investigative judgment. The courtroom is where it takes place.

2 The Presiding Judge: The Ancient of Days

Daniel 7:9–10

Daniel is given a vision of the heavenly courtroom already in session. He sees the Ancient of Days — God the Father — take His seat. His garment is white as snow. His throne is like a fiery flame. Ten thousand times ten thousand stand before Him. The court is seated. The books are opened.

In any courtroom, the judge presides to ensure that the law is followed and that the process is fair. God the Father sits as the Sovereign Judge — not to discover what happened, for He already knows all things. He sits so that the entire universe can see that His decisions are just. Nothing is hidden. Nothing is rushed. The process is open.

KEY INSIGHT

God does not judge in secret. The court is open, the books are available, and the proceedings are witnessed. This is what makes His judgment unlike any human system — it is completely transparent.

3 The Jury: God Does Not Judge Alone

Daniel 7:10 | Fundamental Belief #24

In Daniel 7:10, thousands upon thousands attend the court and ten thousand times ten thousand stand before Him. These are the heavenly intelligences — the angels — who serve as witnesses to the proceedings.

In a human court, a jury of peers is present so that judgment is not left to one person alone. The presence of the jury is a safeguard — it ensures accountability and transparency. God applies this same principle on a cosmic scale.

Fundamental Belief #24 states that the investigative judgment "reveals to heavenly intelligences who among the dead are asleep in Christ and therefore, in Him, are deemed worthy to have part in the first resurrection." The judgment is not for God to learn something new — it is for the universe to witness that God is fair in every decision He makes.

KEY POINT

God invites the angels to hold Him true to His own word. This is not a weakness — it is the highest expression of His integrity. A God who judges in full view of the universe is a God who has nothing to hide.

4 The Advocate: Everything Depends on Your Representation

Daniel 7:13–14 | 1 John 2:1

In any courtroom, the outcome is heavily shaped by the quality of your representation. The advocate speaks on your behalf — he presents the evidence, addresses the judge, and makes the case for your acquittal. You sit and watch. Everything depends on him.



The defendant watches from the table as his advocate addresses the judge and jury. In the heavenly courtroom, Christ stands as our Advocate before the Ancient of Days while the angels look on as witnesses.

Daniel 7:13–14 shows us exactly this moment in the heavenly courtroom. Daniel sees "One like the Son of Man" coming with the clouds of heaven to the Ancient of Days. He is brought before the Judge and given dominion, glory, and a kingdom.

This is Jesus Christ — our Advocate — approaching the Father. 1 John 2:1 makes it plain: *"If anyone sins, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous."* He is not a passive observer. He is standing, speaking, and pleading on our behalf.

The Language of the Defense

Leviticus 17:11

Every courtroom has rules of engagement. There is a specific language that must be spoken. Evidence must be presented in the correct form. For Christ, as our Advocate, the language of the defense is His blood.

Leviticus 17:11 establishes why: *"For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it to you upon the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement for the*

soul." The blood is not merely a symbol — it is the evidence that the penalty for sin has been paid in full. It represents the perfect life of Christ, lived without sin, offered on our behalf.

KEY POINT

When Christ presents His blood before the Father, He is not presenting a ritual — He is presenting the evidence of a perfect life lived and a penalty fully paid. This is His argument on our behalf. No other evidence is required.

Who Is Being Judged?

GC88 480.1

In the typical service, only those who had come before God with confession and repentance, and whose sins, through the blood of the sin-offering, were transferred to the sanctuary, had a part in the service of the day of atonement. So in the great day of final atonement and investigative judgment, the only cases considered are those of the professed people of God.

— *The Great Controversy*, p. 480.1

This is an important clarification. The investigative judgment does not review the records of the whole world indiscriminately — it specifically concerns those who have made a profession of faith. Those who have come before God with confession and repentance and claimed the blood of Christ.

This brings us to a question: what does it mean to make that profession? At baptism into the Seventh-day Adventist Church, every member answers the following questions:

2. Do you accept the death of Jesus Christ on Calvary as the atoning sacrifice for your sins and believe that by God's grace through faith in His shed blood you are saved from sin and its penalty?

3. Do you accept Jesus Christ as your Lord and personal Savior, believing that God, in Christ, has forgiven your sins and given you a new heart, and do you renounce the sinful ways of the world?

4. Do you accept by faith the righteousness of Christ, your Intercessor in the heavenly sanctuary, and accept His promise of transforming grace and power to live a loving, Christ-centered life in your home and before the world?

Baptismal vow questions 2–4. Notice that question 4 specifically names Christ as your Intercessor in the heavenly sanctuary. Every baptised member has already affirmed this doctrine — this lesson is the explanation of the vow you took.

The decision to follow Christ is not merely choosing Him as a personal Saviour in a general sense. It is a conscious affiliation with His ongoing ministry as our High Priest and Advocate in the heavenly sanctuary. Question 4 makes this explicit. The sanctuary doctrine is not peripheral — it is built into the foundation of membership.

5 The Advocate at Work: The Day of Atonement

Leviticus 16:1–4, 29–30

Leviticus 16 shows us the Day of Atonement — the annual day of solemn cleansing in Israel. It is the clearest picture in the Old Testament of what Christ does as our Advocate in the heavenly courtroom.

On this day, the High Priest did something he did on no other day of the year: he set aside his regular garments and dressed in four plain white linen garments before entering the Most Holy Place.



The regular garments of the High Priest as described in Exodus 28 — the ephod, the jewelled breastplate with the twelve stones, the blue robe with golden bells and pomegranates, the golden plate inscribed "HOLINESS TO THE LORD". These are the garments of glory and beauty worn in the Holy Place during regular daily ministry.

Note: *These are not the garments worn on the Day of Atonement. Before entering the Most Holy Place, the High Priest laid all of these aside and put on four plain white linen garments instead — a linen tunic, linen trousers, a linen sash, and a linen turban (Leviticus 16:4). He entered not in garments of glory, but in garments of humility.*

With the blood of the sacrifice, the High Priest entered alone into the Most Holy Place — the place where the presence of God dwelt, above the Mercy Seat, between the two golden cherubim. He sprinkled the blood before the Mercy Seat seven times (Leviticus 16:14). This was the atonement.



The High Priest in plain white linen — the garments of the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16:4) — sprinkling blood before the Mercy Seat on the Ark of the Covenant. The two golden cherubim look down upon the act of atonement as witnesses. This is the picture of Christ our Advocate, presenting His blood before the Ancient of Days on our behalf.

Leviticus 16:30 states the purpose plainly: *"For on that day the priest shall make atonement for you, to cleanse you, that you may be clean from all your sins before the Lord."* The outcome of the Day of Atonement was not left to the people — it depended entirely on the High Priest and what he did in the Most Holy Place. The people waited outside.

This is the picture of our situation. We cannot enter the heavenly courtroom. We cannot plead our own case. We wait — and everything depends on our Advocate, Jesus Christ, and what He presents before the Ancient of Days on our behalf.

All who have truly repented of sin, and by faith claimed the blood of Christ as their atoning sacrifice, have had pardon entered against their names in the books of Heaven; as they have become partakers of the righteousness of Christ, and their characters are found to be in harmony with the law of God, their sins will be blotted out, and they themselves will be accounted worthy of eternal life. The Lord declares, by the prophet Isaiah, "I, even I, am he that blotteth out thy transgressions for mine own sake, and will not remember thy sins."

— *The Great Controversy*, p. 483.2

This is the answer to the question raised at the end of Lesson 5. The Book of Misdeeds holds the record of every sin — but for those who have accepted Christ, pardon has already been entered against their names. His blood covers the record. The Advocate has already spoken.

Isaiah 43:25 | Revelation 3:5 | Matthew 10:32–33

Isaiah 43:25 — God blots out transgressions for His own sake. Revelation 3:5 — Christ promises to confess the names of the overcomers before the Father and His angels. Matthew 10:32–33 — those who confess Christ before men, He will confess before the Father. The Advocate does not only present the blood — He speaks our name.

6 The Heavenly Courtroom: Key Players

To bring everything together, here is how the courtroom model maps to the heavenly reality:

Courtroom Role	Heavenly Reality	Scripture
Judge	God the Father — the Ancient of Days	Daniel 7:9
Jury	Thousands of angels — heavenly witnesses	Daniel 7:10
Advocate	Jesus Christ — our High Priest and Intercessor	Daniel 7:13–14; 1 John 2:1
Evidence	The blood of Christ — His perfect life offered for us	Leviticus 17:11
Defendant	The professed people of God — those who have claimed Christ	GC88 480.1
Case File	The three books of heaven	Daniel 7:10; GC88 481

NEXT
WEEK

Assignment: What happens when the court session ends? Study Revelation 22:11 and Revelation 14:7 carefully. Next week we will bring everything together — the three books, the courtroom, the Advocate, the Day of Atonement — and connect it all back to the First Angel's Message: Fear God, give glory to Him, for the hour of His judgment has come.